

Chapter 32-4

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With time being tight and the task heavy, the director only gave Liang Shi half an hour, then briefly watched her run through scenes with Zhao Ying. Finding that she recited her lines clearly, which passed as acceptable, he had someone take her for makeup and hair.

Modern drama styling was easy to handle, and with Liang Shi's good foundation, it was done in less than ten minutes.

Since cameras tend to wash out makeup, they applied an extra layer of foundation, making her one shade paler than before.

While Liang Shi had previously worn light-colored lipstick, to highlight her villainous temperament, they applied red 999¹ series lipstick—bright red with full commanding presence—and changed her suit to black.

Black suit with white shirt, an extremely striking contrast.

When her styling was complete, the director privately said to Zhao Ying, "Regardless of how her acting is, once made up, her compatibility with the character is quite high."

"Let's wait and see," Zhao Ying said. "Treating a dead horse as if it were alive²."

She first filmed the two scenes with Chen Liuying. Before official filming began, the two had to rehearse together, but Chen Liuying's performance was uncooperative.

During rehearsal, she recited her lines lazily, completely different from Liang Shi's performance. Liang Shi read her lines without much emotion, like loudly reading a text aloud, but she articulated every word very clearly.

The director asked Chen Liuying to put more effort in, but Chen Liuying scoffed, "Why don't you tell her that? She's reciting like reading a textbook—what passion can I have?"

"You're the senior, lead her a bit," the director said. "Have you forgotten how Zhao Ying guided you? Acting can be led."

Chen Liuying didn't argue back, "Oh."

Although she agreed, it was just superficial compliance.

The director was furious inside, silently repeating eight hundred times that he'd be a pig if he ever used internet celebrities again!

Every one of them—poor acting skills but big attitudes.

However, he wasn't completely confident in Liang Shi either, so he could only comfort her, "Just try your best, don't put too much pressure on yourself."

"Okay, thank you, Director," Liang Shi politely thanked him.

They first filmed the water-splashing scene. Because a junior employee brought the wrong document, the female executive angrily grabbed a cup of water and splashed it, soaking the employee's shirt completely, followed by a long speech requiring imposing momentum.

Worried that Liang Shi couldn't handle it, the director initially didn't put water in the cup, saying they'd try once after cameras rolled.

He hadn't hoped for a single take anyway—getting something decent after ten takes would be worth thanking heaven for.

As filming approached, everyone on set actually became nervous too, whispering discussions.

"Can she really do it? The newcomer's line reading isn't even as good as Lu Ci's."

"Not even as good as Chen Liuying when she first started acting."

"I think the newcomer is about to get crushed by Chen Liuying."

"As a senior, crushing a newcomer is pretty normal, right? What's worth bragging about?"

"Given Chen Liuying's temper, the newcomer will probably get scolded to death."

"Lighting a candle for her."

"..."

A small assistant asked Zhao Ying, "Sister Ying, can she really do it?"

"I don't know," Zhao Ying answered honestly. "That face is indeed suited for cameras."

Small assistant: "..."

The director sat behind the camera, also feeling somewhat apprehensive, but having mentally prepared himself fully, he had the script supervisor get ready to begin.

The sound recording and cameras were all ready on set.

In the distance was an endless grassland, with Liang Shi sitting under the canopy to cool off.

Soon, Chen Liuying entered the frame, "President Qian³, here's the information you requested."

Liang Shi took off her sunglasses, glanced casually, pinched a corner of the document with two fingers, looked at her, and delivered her first line: "Which department are you from?"

Chen Liuying: "Marketing department."

Liang Shi smiled contemptuously, looked down at the document, but as she read, her brow furrowed. She directly threw the document at Chen Liuying, "You can't even get the simplest document right—what are you doing at work?"

"No, President Qian, this is exactly what you asked for..."

"You dare talk back?"

Liang Shi raised a cup of water and splashed it over.

...

Liang Shi hadn't acted for a long time, so facing the camera again made her slightly nervous, preventing her from displaying all her acting skills.

But even this little bit was enough.

When acting opposite Chen Liuying, she didn't lose ground at all, even managing to portray that arrogant and domineering energy, especially in her eye acting.

The director was quite shocked. After she finished this scene, he called cut, then applauded continuously, and had the crew touch up her makeup while props filled the cup with water.

The director picked up his megaphone and shouted loudly, "Liang Shi, just maintain this state and act well—strive for one take! Liuying, your attitude was a bit too firm just now, soften it more, be more pitiful. Alright, after we adjust, we'll officially film one take."

Having had one practice run, Liang Shi had grasped the feeling.

After throwing the papers at Chen Liuying, they scattered like heavenly flowers, A4 sheets floating everywhere. "Is this how you do your job? Three years in the company and you still get documents wrong!"

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This scene made everyone clench their fists, especially when Chen Liuying silently crouched down to pick up the documents and Liang Shi stepped on them again.

Her high heel ruthlessly punctured through the paper.

Liang Shi frowned and said, "Useless waste who can't do anything deserves a miserable life."

She delivered this line to the camera, with proper intonation and emotion, lowering her voice as if speaking to each person in front of the screen—the sense of immersion was too strong.

After she lifted her foot, she took tissues to wipe her hands, methodically.

The tissue wiped across her slender fingers, and in the camera, she was a complete beautiful and crazed villain.

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Not sure who started applauding first, but then thunderous applause erupted on set.

"Holy shit, the newcomer's acting is this strong?"

"I'm totally immersed—a beautiful crazy villain is the most compelling!"

"My god! Who said the newcomer can't act?! She'll be Best Actress at next year's Magnolia Awards!"

"I thought Chen Liuying's acting could crush the newcomer, but she got crushed by the newcomer instead."

"Worthy of being someone chosen by Sister Ying—really too strong!"

"..."

Their scattered discussions also reached Liang Shi's ears, and she finally breathed a sigh of relief.

Fortunately, all those years of effort weren't wasted.

Those days and nights of practicing lines in front of mirrors to shape characters well, those screenwriting books read to understand scripts and characters, those days of running around on film sets.

All the sweat and tears shed on this path were accumulation.

She first looked toward Zhao Ying, who gave her a thumbs up.

Footnotes:

¹ Red 999: A reference to a popular bright red lipstick shade, often associated with bold, confident looks

² Treating a dead horse as if it were alive: Chinese idiom meaning to try everything possible even when the situation seems hopeless

³ President Qian: The character name for the role Liang Shi is playing (Qian is a surname)